

The list of those who have achieved great success by refusing to accept and follow established patterns is a long one. It spans two centuries of American history and runs the alphabetical gamut from John Jacob Astor to Adolph Zukor. These men relied on those four qualities already enumerated: their own imagination, originality, individualism and initiative. They made good—while the rock-ribbed conformists remained by the wayside.

The conformists simply do not realize that only the least able and efficient among them derive any benefit from the dubious blessings of conformism. The best men are inevitably dragged down to the insipid levels at which the second-raters—the prigs, pedants, precisians and procrastinators—set the pace. The craze for conformity is having its effect on our entire civilization—and, the way I see it, the effect is far from a salubrious one. It isn't a very long step from a conformist society to a regimented society.

Although it would take longer to create an Orwellian nightmare through voluntary surrender of individuality—

and thus of independence—than through totalitarian edict,

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the results would be very much the same. In some respects, a society in which the members reach a universal level in which they are anonymous drones by choice is even more frightening than one in which they are forced to be so against their will. When human beings relinquish their individuality and identity of their own volition, they are also relinquishing their claim to being human.

In business, the mystique of conformity is sapping the dynamic individualism that is the most priceless quality an executive or businessman can possibly possess. It has produced the lifeless, cardboard-cutout figure of the organization man who tries vainly to hide his fears, lack of confidence and incompetence behind the stylized facades of conformity.

The conformist is not born. He is made. I believe the brainwashing process begins in the schools and colleges.